VYNEMA STUDIO · THE SEND CHECKLIST

Why one Reel dies and another spreads.

Instagram's head, Adam Mosseri, has named three top signals for ranking Reels. Below: what each one does, 16 practices that feed them, and which claims come from Instagram vs. creator data. None of it guarantees reach.

✓ CONFIRMED · INSTAGRAM CREATOR DATA

CONFIRMED = STATED BY INSTAGRAM OR ITS HEAD, ADAM MOSSERI. CREATOR DATA = STUDIES AND CONSENSUS FROM CREATORS AND TOOL VENDORS. IT'S USEFUL, BUT NOT OFFICIAL.

The scoreboard

Watch time

✓ CONFIRMED

One of the three top signals Mosseri named, often summarised as the most important. Track average watch time in Insights.

Sends per reach

✓ CONFIRMED

DM shares. Per Mosseri, they count slightly more for reaching people who don't follow you yet.

Likes per reach

✓ CONFIRMED

They still count. Per Mosseri, they count slightly more with people who already follow you.

Comments • saves

CREATOR DATA

Widely treated as supporting signals. Instagram hasn't published weights.

Timing

CREATOR DATA

Reported to be a small effect, and Instagram hasn't quantified it. Your own Insights beat any published study.

"Slightly" is Mosseri's word in his January 2025 explanation. Nobody outside Instagram knows the exact weights, so treat any "1 send = X likes" formula as made up.

The 16 rules

01 Hook in the first 1–2 seconds.

Motion or on-screen text inside the first half-second, hook text under 10 words. No logos, greetings or slow intros.

CREATOR DATA

02 Keep it as short as the idea allows.

Shorter Reels complete more often. One 2026 creator dataset found 5–15 s Reels finish around 88% of the time, against about 28% for 60–90 s. It's one vendor dataset, so read it as a direction, not a promise.

CREATOR DATA

03 Build for the loop.

Watch time is a confirmed top signal. Creators find that an ending that flows back into the start earns replays, which can add to it.

WATCH TIME · CONFIRMED LOOP / REPLAYS · CREATOR DATA

04 Design one "send this" moment.

Sends per reach is one of Instagram's three named signals, and it counts slightly more for reaching people who don't follow you yet. Give viewers one thing they'd DM to a specific friend.

✓ CONFIRMED · INSTAGRAM

05 End with one specific question.

"Which one fails, A or B?" beats "comment below". Avoid "like this to win" wording, which can read as engagement bait.

CREATOR DATA

06 Reply to comments early.

Buffer analysed 700K+ Instagram posts from about 68K accounts and found roughly 21% higher engagement on posts where the creator replied, compared with the same account's baseline. That's a correlation, not proof. Buffer suggests replying in the first few hours; "the first hour" is a creator rule of thumb.

CREATOR DATA · BUFFER

07 Post around your audience's active hours.

Find them in Insights → Total followers → Most active times. A common creator tip is to post about an hour before the peak. Test it and compare results. Timing is reported to be a small effect, not a growth engine.

CREATOR DATA

08 Caption: keyword first.

Lead with the phrase a viewer would search, keep it around 150 characters, end with your one question. Instagram reads captions, on-screen text and speech to work out your topic.

CREATOR DATA

09 Five hashtags or fewer.

Use 3–5 specific tags as labels. Hashtags appear to play a small role in distribution, and stuffing 30 shows no benefit in creator data. A cap of 5 has been reported since Dec 2025 but isn't verified here, so check in the app.

CREATOR DATA

10 Export 1080×1920, 9:16, 30 fps.

Keep key text and faces in the centre, because the profile grid crops to 3:4. Upload a custom cover. 30 fps is a common choice, not a requirement.

SPEC · CREATOR DATA

11 Always add on-screen text and subtitles.

Many people watch on mute, and the text helps both viewers and Instagram understand the topic.

CREATOR DATA

12 Make it original.

Instagram prioritises original content in recommendations. Accounts that mainly repost others' work without material changes may lose recommendation eligibility. Creators also avoid other-app watermarks.

✓ INSTAGRAM POLICY · WATERMARKS · CREATOR DATA

13 Rework a flop instead of reposting it.

Creators report that the repost does worse. If a Reel deserves a second shot, re-edit it materially (new hook, new pacing) and space it out. Instagram has never confirmed a penalty.

CREATOR DATA · UNCONFIRMED

14 Test hooks with Trial Reels.

Trial Reels are shown to non-followers first and stay off your grid until you share them. Change one thing (the hook), compare trial against trial, then share the winner.

✓ INSTAGRAM FEATURE · METHOD · CREATOR DATA

15 Post 2–3 quality Reels a week.

Pick a pace you can hold for 90 days. Judge each Reel on its own numbers, and remember that account-level recommendation eligibility also affects reach.

CREATOR DATA

16 Reach dropped? Check Account Status first.

Settings → Account Status shows whether your content is eligible for recommendations and any flagged violations. Check it before blaming "the algorithm".

✓ INSTAGRAM FEATURE

Pre-post check

- [ ] First frame hooks: motion or text right away, no logo or greeting
- [ ] The ending loops cleanly into the start
- [ ] One "send this to…" moment
- [ ] On-screen text and subtitles on, inside the safe zones

- [ ] 1080×1920, 9:16, 30 fps, audio present
- [ ] Custom cover, key text centred for the 3:4 grid
- [ ] Caption: keyword first, ends with one specific question
- [ ] 3–5 specific hashtags (a 5-tag cap is reported)
- [ ] Original: not someone else's work reposted without material changes
- [ ] Posting about an hour before your Insights peak
- [ ] Time blocked out to reply to comments early

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Claimed everywhere, proven nowhere

"1 send = 15 likes" or "sends are worth 3–5× a like."
Instagram has never published a coefficient. In his January 2025 explanation, Mosseri's word was "slightly".

The 24-hour caption-edit penalty.
Community lore with no official confirmation. Still, proofread before posting.

The delete-and-repost penalty.
Widely advised against, but never officially confirmed.

Exact posting-time multipliers.
They come from single datasets, often covering every post type rather than Reels alone.

Creator vs Business ranking advantage.
We found no published evidence either way.

Sources

Mosseri on the three signals (Jan 2025): Social Media Today · Future Social
Reply lift (700K+ posts): Buffer, Jan 2026 · Posting times: Buffer
Completion by length: IShort 2026 dataset · Hashtags: frameos.studio
Originality: creatortribune.com (summary of Instagram's update) · Trial Reels: postfa.st

Compiled Oct 2026 from Instagram's public guidance and published creator datasets, without signed-in app verification. Platform rules change, so re-check anything marked creator data in the app.

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